Meridian Health Trust

Internal Review: Escalation Handling at the Exeter Site

RESTRICTED — prepared for release under FOI request 2024/0417

1. Background

This review was commissioned following a serious incident reported at the Exeter site in February 2024. The review was led by the Director of Governance and Risk, who has held the post since March 2019 and is based at the Bristol headquarters.

The reviewing director was appointed from a national regulatory body, where they had led inspection policy. The interview panel was chaired by the Chief Executive, [redacted], on 14 March 2019.

2. Findings

The review found that escalation thresholds were applied inconsistently across the four sites. Staff at Exeter reported reluctance to escalate owing to perceived workload consequences.

The reviewing director noted, as they have publicly before, that "if your incident numbers are going down, either you have solved patient safety or people have stopped telling you things."

3. Declarations

The reviewing director declared a personal connection to a member of the investigating panel and recused themselves from panel selection. A separate declared interest concerning an immediate family member employed by a Trust supplier was recorded in 2022 and is managed by exclusion from procurement.

4. Recommendations

Fourteen recommendations are made, of which eleven mirror those accepted following the external review reported to the Board in June 2023.